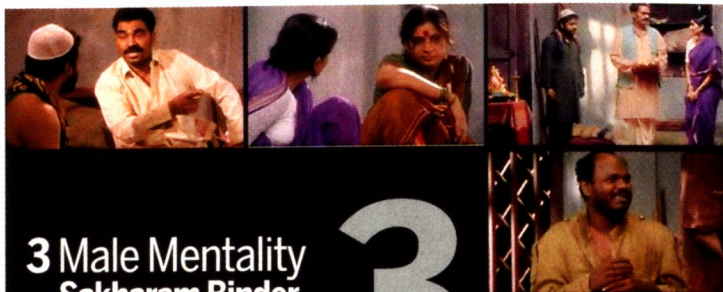


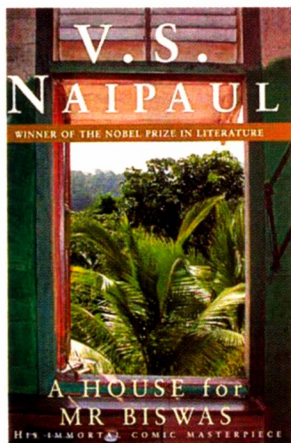
greatest indian literary characters

From Mohun Biswas's search for an identity to Asha Rani's starry romps, Indian authors' flights of fancy have given us many pageturners



3 Male Mentality Sakharam Binder

Vijay Tendulkar's *Sakharam Binder*, a hard-hitting play first staged in 1972, is about a man, disdainful of covert sexual practices, who takes on several ditched women as either domestic helps or sexual partners, until his own arrangements make his life complicated. Sakharam's depiction sparked off several questions. Is he the quintessential Indian male who objectifies women? Or is he a departure because he is open about his sexual life? The argument continues.



1 Home Truth Mohun Biswas

Not quite what we know as the Indian diasporic hero today, but Mohun Biswas's existential angst in V.S. Naipaul's *A House for Mr Biswas* (1961) is shared by almost every Indian trying to gain economic independence. It is a microcosm of the migrant Indian, who doesn't have a place to call his own.

2 Bhadraklok Sleuth Feluda

Many would argue that Satyajit Ray's Feluda novels, which first appeared in 1965 in Bengali, can in no way be called high literature. And they would be right. But Feluda's inclusion in the list is merely because he is India's answer to Sherlock Holmes. Feluda or Prodosh Mitra is probably a representative of the ideal Bengali *bhadraklok*,

who has a sharp mind, a great thirst for knowledge, and, can show great courage under fire.



4 Witness to Change Payyan

Payyan, V.K.N. Nair's creation in the 1970s, is the most endearing character for all journalists from Kerala, and probably for everyone else as well. "A cross between a dandy, obsessed with food and sex, and a gimlet-eyed journalist," as described by critic V. Rajakrishnan, Payyan was witness to the dramatic swing in political values in the post-Nehruvian era. He was an alter-ego for Nair, who was a journalist himself.

VIJAY TENDULKAR PAINTED SAKHARAM BINDER
WITH AN UNSETTLING COMPASSION